

THE 5 PATTERNS

What the Best Carousels Quietly Do Differently

By Tinna Loaiza

I've found something that quite honestly surprised me. Most of the people I've worked with don't struggle with getting their carousels to work because they lack ideas on what to post. They actually know their craft, but the way they say it feels empty. It doesn't create any type of connection with the person reading it.

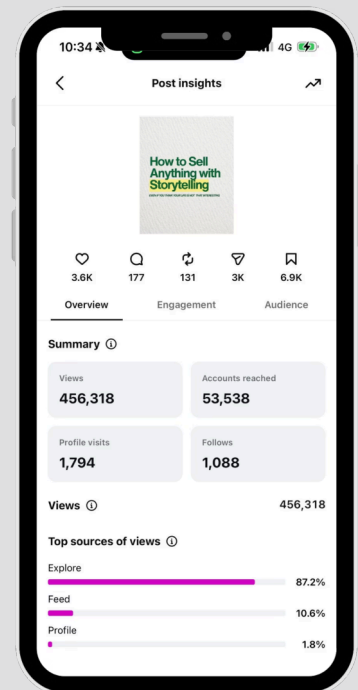
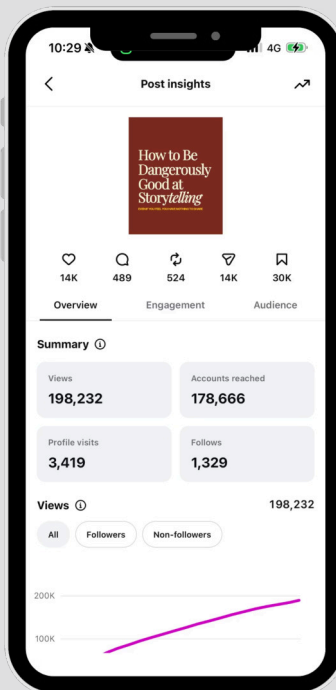
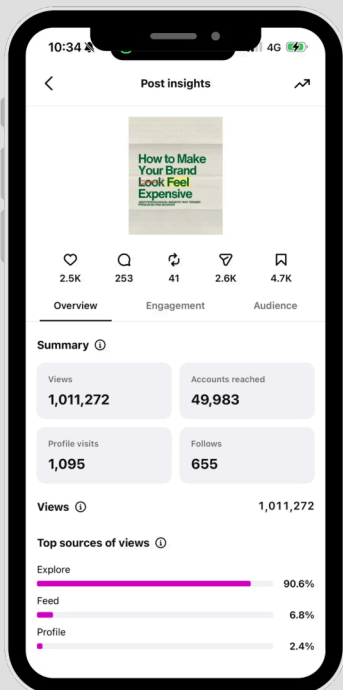
Yes, they might get a ton of likes and saves, but at the end of the day, they don't have that edge that makes people trust them or come back for more.

That's exactly what pushed me to study well over 500 carousels in the last few months — after being convinced that “carousels just didn't work for me.”

That wasn't the case.

There were patterns hiding in plain sight in almost every single piece of content that was actually working.

Today, I'm sharing them with you.



Intimacy

These types of carousels feel more like a letter from someone who knows you rather than an ad in the newspaper from a complete stranger who doesn't care who you are.

And no, this doesn't apply only to personal stories or lifestyle content. The kind of intimacy I am referring to here is that special kind that makes you feel seen. It speaks to you in an uncondescending way. There is no pedestal, no toxic authority. It has the same phrases, fears, and hopes you have been quietly mumbling in your head.

It sees you. You recognise yourself, and it makes you feel safe.

This is usually where people start overthinking and turn this into a collage of sounding helpful, a little bit polished, and trying to hold it together so their audience knows for sure they are "legit." So before you drive yourself into trying to perform intimacy — the point here is not to write like you are emotionally undressing in front of millions of strangers, but to make them feel like you actually understand their side.

Something I do quite frequently is sit down and write in no particular order. I don't think about the structure or the goal, I just let the door open and start typing. The end result feels a little bit like this thing you are reading. Like an overheard conversation someone is having with themselves.

And if typing doesn't seem to do the trick, record a voice memo on your phone and respond to these 3 questions:

Why This

What is the importance of that topic you want to talk about?

Why Me

What is your stance — why are you even talking about this?

Why Now

How is this relevant now to the people who will read it?

This is where most carousels already start separating themselves. When your reader feels seen, they don't need to be convinced to keep reading. It's just something they do intuitively.

Deprivation Curiosity

This is big.

And you know what's funny — I almost couldn't get to the root. Like yes, I get it, "make them curious." But you know how most curiosity-driven statements on social media are kind of predictable? We can see through it. And it ends up creating the complete opposite effect.

It's not enough to get you to swipe and leaves this bittersweet, clickbaity aftertaste.

The curiosity you are going to strive for is more sophisticated.

- It cannot be obvious
- It cannot be predictable
- It cannot feel hyped

It's like you are giving away a piece of gold. You already know how valuable it is. You don't go and shout to people, "this piece of gold is worth £1,000,000, I am about to make you rich." You just open the door and say — here it is.

Deprivation curiosity works when there is an open loop, an untapped opportunity, or the possibility of incurring a loss by not avoiding some type of "danger." The result of ignoring this is the loss of something substantial.

So take whatever topic you want to talk about and ask yourself this:

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|--|---|---|
| → Is this topic a solution to something? | → How is this something currently manifesting in their lives? | → What happens if they don't take the solution? |
|--|---|---|

⚠️ Knowing this is one thing. Knowing how to use it without sounding dramatic, clickbaity, or like you're trying too hard to be chosen is where most people get stuck. That is the difference between curiosity that low-key opens a loop and curiosity that makes people roll their eyes and lose connection with you.

Tension

You cannot give it all away in the first two slides. Come on. Think of the movies that keep you watching and guessing. There is anticipation, there are lingering questions, or sides to take. Tension allows them to put some skin in the game.

Too Much, Too Soon

They give everything away too quickly, so there is no reason to keep reading.

Too Vague

They stay so vague that the reader has no idea what they are supposed to care about.

Tension is the Middle

It gives them something to question, maybe something they can compare to what they are doing, or a type of mental puzzle that needs resolving.

One way of doing this is comparing two options, approaches, or methods. But it doesn't work if one of the options is obviously superior. The tension is created when there is room for each possibility to be the "correct" one.

LOW TENSION

Should you walk or drive to work?

You already know driving is faster than walking. There's no real tension here — the answer is obvious before you even finish the question.

HIGH TENSION

Should you take the blue bus or the red bus?

Now you are faced with two valid options, and it's not obvious which one is the best choice. That uncertainty is what keeps people reading.

Visual Repetition

Look, I know that the creative artist in you wishes they could create a masterpiece every time you sit down to create content. But here's the truth — you will get tired of your aesthetic and visuals much faster than your audience.

Creators who are leveraging this format create a type of visual imprint in their audience's mind that helps them get recognised even before they check who wrote it.



Pick a Style

Whether it is editorial, handmade, or camera roll with text on it — commit to a visual direction that feels like you.



Build 3–4 Templates

Create a small set of starting points you can use every single time. Consistency is the product.



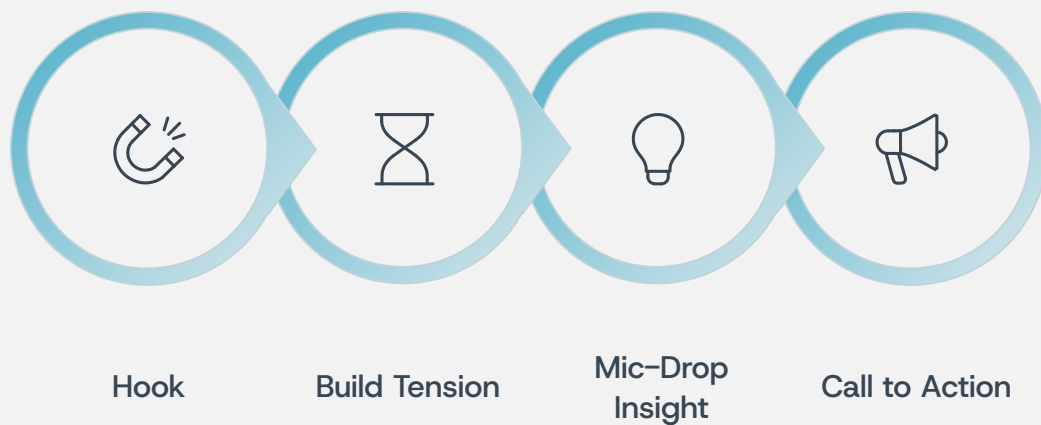
Activate the Fast Brain

When your audience's mind recognises you faster, they bypass "who is this?" and dive straight into "ok, their stuff is good."

- ⓘ Before someone trusts you, they usually need to remember you exist first. If your content has been feeling inconsistent or like it doesn't set itself apart from everything else on Instagram, this is one of the reasons — you are not giving people enough visual memory to recognise you faster.

Narrative

Think of carousels like dating someone. You are not going to ask them to marry you on your first date. You are going to build the relationship. So don't start firing credentials and social proof in the first few slides. You need to earn this.



Most people try to make one carousel do everything at once — teach, prove, connect, sell, explain the whole backstory, add the CTA, sprinkle some personality on top. And then they wonder why it feels like the format "is not working."

✗ The Whole Room

Throws everything at the reader and hopes they find the door. No guide, no arc, no earned trust.

✓ The Guide

A good carousel moves people through something. It guides them. It earns the right to ask something at the end.

Now, the Action Begins

If you've made it this far, you've probably caught yourself in a few of these. Some things you're doing are working. Some are close. And some... you can kind of feel where people lose interest, even if you can't fully explain it yet.

This is the part most people don't love. Because yes, knowing these patterns helps. But that doesn't automatically mean you know how to *use* them. Not in a way that feels natural, anyway.

1

They understand intimacy, but there is no tension or positioning.

It's kind of forgettable.

2

They try to create curiosity and it ends up sounding clickbaity.

People can feel that. No real pull.

3

They put everything into one carousel.

It just feels like some weird salad that leaves you feeling a bit sick. No purpose.



So pleaseeee don't just read this and think "that makes sense" and leave it there. Go back to your last few posts and actually look at them. Where do you lose people? Where are you coming across as rushed or pushy? That's the work — and it can take a bit longer than people expect.

This format only starts working once there's enough repetition behind it. So this is not about trying it for a couple of days or whenever you feel inspired. You need to give it a proper go.

I'll be talking more about this over the next few days — what it actually looks like when it's working, and what to do when you sit down to create so the whole thing is put together intentionally and actually gets seen.

For now, just pick one thing and try it. And if something made you think "ok, this is kinda weird but makes sense" while you were reading this, send me a message and tell me what it was. That's usually the part that is going to make the biggest difference for you.

Thank you for reading my novel.

Chat soon.

Tinna